

SOUND QUALITY

The driver setup is similar to the standard Realme Buds Air 8: 11mm + 6mm duo, and you also get support for high-res LHDC 5.0 codec. The tuning has familiar attributes like good, strong bass, clear vocals and safe highs, but all of these aspects are enhanced for an even more expressive sound.

Take the 'Vallah' song from Cocktail 2, for instance, the sub-bass, dhol beats and other instruments sound tighter and tastier. Nick Hakim's I Don't Know has a very atmospheric presence on the Buds Air 8 Pro. The voice of the lead vocalist from Alabama Shakes' Don't Wanna Fight and the guitar riff both reach the corners of my mind on this pair. In The Temptations' My Girl, the high vocals and instruments in the high frequencies sound clear and not-so-harsh. So much is happening on the Buds Air 8 Pro compared to the Buds Air 8, and due to this, the 8 Pro could seem more fatiguing to some. But, I am sure, most would find the Pro's tuning more interesting than the standard model.

You can tweak the sound to some extent using EQ mode, Spatial Audio, High-definition sound, Dynamic audio, and Golden sound settings in the Realme Link app. The Golden sound option is not available on the standard Buds Air 8 model.

All in all, it is one of the best-sounding earphones in the range and easily recommendable to the mainstream audience.

ANC AND CALLS

Realme claims up to 55dB active noise cancellation, and the ANC performance is genuinely impressive. There is wind-noise reduction, also. I was choosing the Max mode from the different EQ modes in the Realme Link app. Even in this, you will hear sudden, random sounds occasionally, and I didn't mind that at all. On the other end of the spectrum, the Transparency mode also sounded reasonably natural.

Compared to a budget pair of earbuds I reviewed recently, this one offered



a clear improvement in call quality. I preferred using the Buds Air 8 Pro while calling my wife from the office. The combination of six microphones and the dedicated bone-conduction sensor isolates your voice well. Both of us could hear each other properly without any noticeable background noise.

So good sound for entertainment and calls, and a good shield against outside noise are ample reasons to like this Realme offering.

BATTERY LIFE AND CHARGING

With ANC disabled, at 80% volume level, and AAC codec, playing a FLAC file, the earbuds ran for 10 hours 40 minutes. With the case, the brand claims up to 50 hours of battery life. This is lower than the Buds Air 8's claimed runtime, but it is still plenty long. Just with the buds, you can easily get through a workday and say you are going on a 4-day vacay, the Buds Air 8 Pro should last the entire trip. Turning ANC on naturally reduces endurance, but the overall battery life remains competitive.

This is backed by fast charging support. Realme gives an estimate of

11 hours worth of playback from just 10 minutes of charging. Good figures.

SHOULD YOU BUY?

Well, the review period is over, and I will still be keeping these as my default earbuds for daily metro rides, office work, movie sessions, and phone calls. That, more than any specification, says a lot about how good they are.

The Realme Buds Air 8 Pro improves upon the standard Buds Air 8 in meaningful ways. The sound is more expressive and engaging, ANC is stronger, call quality is excellent, and features like triple-device connectivity, swipe volume controls, and Golden Sound add genuine value to the overall experience.

The only area that sees a slight downgrade from the Buds Air 8 is battery life. Even then, it has more than the required juice for daily use and can comfortably last through a long weekend trip. During everyday use, the Realme Link app has a lot of useful features, but the AI-powered ones didn't feel particularly polished in my experience.

The glossy elements of the design are also not to my personal taste because of their reflective, smudge-prone finish. That said, they do help the earbuds stand out, and these are more personal preferences than actual drawbacks. They don't meaningfully affect what is otherwise an excellent pair of earbuds.

So yes, I can comfortably recommend the Realme Buds Air 8 Pro at its asking price of Rs 6,999.

—G S Vasan

SPECIFICATIONS

Driver: Coaxial Dual-Driver 11mm | ANC: Upto 55dB | Audio Codecs: LHDC 5.0, AAC, SBC | Connectivity: Bluetooth 6.1 | Microphone: 6-mic system with ENC | Battery Life(Buds): Upto 12 hours | Battery Life(With case): Upto 50 hours | Weight: 4.6g per earbud

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